

The Pont du Gard

Crossing the River Gard in the South of France, the Pont du Gard is part of the Nîmes aqueduct, built c.40–50 CE to carry water from a spring at Uzès to the Roman city of Nemausus (Nîmes). General Marcus Agrippa, son-in-law and aide of Emperor Augustus, is credited with its conception. Although the direct distance between the two is only about 20 kilometres (12 miles), the aqueduct takes a winding route of about 50 kilometres (30 miles) to avoid the Garrigue hills above Nîmes. The tallest of all elevated Roman aqueducts, the Pont du Gard has three tiers of arches, and rises to a height of 48.8 metres (160 ft).

The first tier is composed of six arches, each 15–24 metres (51–80 ft) wide, with the largest spanning the river; the second tier has 11 arches of similar dimensions; while the third, carrying the conduit, consists of 35 smaller arches, each spanning 4.5 metres (15 ft). Like many ancient Roman structures, the Pont du Gard was built without mortar, and is a great example of the precision that Roman engineers were able to achieve.

